

ABHIT BHANDARI

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Vanderbilt University

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, 2023–present

Temple University

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, 2021–2023

Institute for Advanced Study in Toulouse

Postdoctoral Research Fellow, 2020–2021

EDUCATION

Columbia University

Ph.D., Political Science, 2020

M.Phil., Political Science, 2016

M.A., Political Science, 2015

Northwestern University

B.A., Political Science (honors) and African Studies, 2012

RESEARCH

BOOK PROJECTS

Property Rights for Some: Political Connections and Markets Under Selective Rule of Law. *Under review.*

Connected Careers: Entrepreneurial Trajectories Under Political Inequality (with Robert Kubinec). *In progress.*

PUBLICATIONS

“Substitutes For Rule of Law? How BITs Deepen But Do Not Broaden U.S. Investment in Developing Countries,” with Joonseok Yang. 2025. Forthcoming, *International Interactions*.

“Able and Mostly Willing: An Empirical Anatomy of Information’s Effect on Voter-Driven Accountability in Senegal,” with Horacio Larreguy and John Marshall. 2023. *American Journal of Political Science* 67(4):1040–1066.

“Social, Formal, and Political Determinants of Trade Under Weak Rule of Law: Experimental Evidence from Senegalese Firms.” 2023. *Comparative Political Studies* 56(2):163–192.

“Political Determinants of Economic Exchange: Evidence from a Business Experiment in Senegal.” 2022. *American Journal of Political Science* 66(4):835–852.

→ **Michael Wallerstein Award** for Best Article in Political Economy, APSA, 2023

“Nation-State or Nation-Family? Nationalism in Marginalized African Societies,” with Lisa Mueller. 2019. *Journal of Modern African Studies* 57(2):297–322.

WORKING PAPERS

“Access Denied: How Partisanship and Gender Bias Limit Private-Sector Development in the Global South.”

→ **Best Paper Award**, Class and Inequality Section, APSA, 2024

“Political Connections, Patronage, and Consumer Attitudes: Evidence from Morocco,” with Erin York. *Under review*.

“The Political Nature of Entrepreneurship in Developing Countries: Experimental Evidence from Tunisia and Senegal,” with Robert Kubinec, Sekou Jabateh, and Hamza Mighri. *Under review*.

“Formalizing Inequality? Firms’ Political Connections and the Limits of Institutions in Developing Markets.” *Under review*.

“Private-Sector Support for Programmatic Candidates: Evidence from Senegal,” with Lucas Borba and Jessica Gottlieb. *Under review*.

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

“The Economic Costs of Favoritism,” with Horacio Larreguy.

“Economics, Politics, and the Rule of Law: An Experiment in Formalization,” with Jessica Gottlieb.

“Political Formalization Cycles: How Political Uncertainty Can Promote Economic Development,” with Lucas Borba.

“Who Controls Private-Sector Development? Bureaucratic Origins and Preferential Access to Economic Growth.”

OTHER WRITING

“African Countries Are Opening Their Borders. What Does This Mean for Security, Identity and Trade?” with Lisa Mueller. *The Washington Post*. August 13, 2019.

AWARDS, GRANTS, AND FELLOWSHIPS

EXTERNAL

Best Paper Award for best article presented in previous year, APSA Class and Inequality Section, 2024

Michael Wallerstein Award for best article in political economy published in previous year, APSA Political Economy Section, 2023

Centre for Economic Policy Research (CEPR) - Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries (PEDL), 2019, £38,371.

National Science Foundation (NSF) Graduate Research Fellowship (GRFP), 2015-18, \$138,000.

Centre for Economic Policy Research (CEPR) - Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries (PEDL), 2017, £29,944.

National Science Foundation (NSF) Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grant (DDRIG), 2017, \$18,900.

Spencer Foundation (with Horacio Larreguy and John Marshall), 2017, \$50,000.

J-PAL Governance Initiative Seed Grant, 2016, \$5,036.

Social Science Research Council (SSRC) Dissertation Proposal Development Fellowship, 2015, \$5,000.

INTERNAL

Summer Research Award, Temple University, 2022.

Grant-in-Aid for Research/Creative Activity, Temple University, 2022.

College of Liberal Arts Research Award (CLARA), Temple University, 2021.

Liberal Arts Undergraduate Research Award (LAURA), Temple University, 2021.

Katerina Alevizaki Dracopoulos Summer Fellowship, Columbia University, 2017.

Dissertation Development Grant, Columbia University, 2016.

Schiff Fellowship, Columbia University, 2015.

Dean's Fellowship, Columbia University, 2013.

African Research Leadership Award, Northwestern University, 2011.

Provost's Undergraduate Research Grant, Northwestern University, 2011.

National Merit Scholarship, Northwestern University, 2008-12.

AFFILIATIONS

Member, Evidence in Governance and Politics (EGAP), 2025–present.

Faculty Affiliate, Center for the Study of Democratic Institutions (CSDI), 2025–present.

TEACHING

COURSES TAUGHT

African Politics (undergraduate lecture)

Comparative Politics of Developing Countries (undergraduate lecture)

Business and Politics in the Global South (undergraduate seminar)

Studies in Comparative Analysis (Ph.D. seminar)

States and Markets (Ph.D. seminar)

Political Economy of Development (Ph.D. seminar)

OTHER TEACHING

Spatial Econometrics Graduate Workshop, African School of Economics. 2015.

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

* = invited talk

2025: American Political Science Association (APSA); NYU Comparative Politics Series*

2024: Southern Political Science Association (SPSA); LSE African Political Economy Group*; University of California, Berkeley Comparative Politics Series*; MIT Comparative Politics Series*; Copenhagen Business School Money in Politics; European Political Science Association (EPSA); American Political Science Association (APSA)

2023: Washington University in St. Louis Comparative Politics Series*; NYU, Rebecca B. Morton Conference on Experimental Political Science; University of Connecticut, Business and Human Rights Initiative Speaker Series*; Columbia University, Seminar for the Study of Development Strategies*; Copenhagen Business School Money in Politics; European Political Science Association (EPSA); American Political Science Association (APSA)

2022: Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA); American Political Science Association (APSA); Copenhagen Business School Money in Politics; European Political Science Association (EPSA); Institute for Advanced Study in Toulouse; Enda Espace de coproduction et des offres populaires pour l'environnement et le développement, Senegal

2021: American Political Science Association (APSA); Enda Espace de coproduction et des offres populaires pour l'environnement et le développement, Senegal

2020: American Political Science Association (APSA); Office of Evaluation Sciences, Washington, D.C.; Toulouse School of Economics

2019: Yale University, Institution for Social and Policy Studies*; NYU-Columbia Political Economy of Informal Institutions Workshop; Harvard University, Department of African and African American Studies*; Working Group in African Political Economy (WGAPE), NYU Abu Dhabi; American Political Science Association (APSA)

2018: Northeast Workshop in Empirical Political Science (NEWEPS), UPenn; Contemporary African Political Economy Research Seminar (CAPERS), NYU; American Political Science Association (APSA); Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA); African Studies Association (ASA)

2017: WZB, Berlin, Germany; PEDL, Oxford University; Harvard Experiments Working Group; Macalester College; American Political Science Association (APSA); Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA); African Studies Association (ASA)

2016: Working Group in African Political Economy (WGAPE), NYU Abu Dhabi; American Political Science Association (APSA); Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA); African Studies Association (ASA)

SERVICE

DISCIPLINARY

Reviewer:

American Journal of Political Science, American Political Science Review, British Journal of Political Science, Business and Politics, Electoral Studies, International Organization, International Interactions, International Studies Quarterly, Journal of Politics, Political Behavior, Social Science Quarterly, Studies in Ethnicity and Nationalism, World Politics

Committees:

APSA Experimental Research Section, Board Member (incoming), 2026–
APSA Mentor, 2022–2023

Award committees:

APSA Political Economy Section, Mancur Olson Dissertation Award, 2024.
African Politics Research Group, Ralph Bunche Best Graduate Student Paper, 2023.
APSA Class and Inequality Section, Best Paper on Entrepreneurship and Inclusion, 2022.

UNIVERSITY AND DEPARTMENT

Vanderbilt Political Science Undergraduate Committee. 2024.
Vanderbilt Political Science Comparative Politics Subfield Convener. 2023–2024.
Temple Political Science Undergraduate Committee. 2021–2023.
Temple Fulbright Campus Committee. 2021–2023.
Columbia Political Science Undergraduate Advisor. 2016–17.
Coordinator, Columbia Political Economy Seminar. 2015–16.
Coordinator, Contemporary African Political Economy Research Seminar (CAPERS). 2013–14.

POLICY WORK

Research collaborator, World Bank DIME Governance Program. 2021.
Consultant, DRG Impact Evaluation, USAID Senegal (contracted by NORC). 2015–17.
Fellow, UN World Food Programme (WFP), West Africa Regional Bureau, Dakar, Senegal. 2012–13.

SKILLS

Languages: French (fluent)
Programming: R, Stata, L^AT_EX, ArcGIS/QGIS, Open Data Kit/SurveyCTO/Qualtrics
Field research: Senegal, Niger, Mozambique, Gambia

Last updated October 2025